Grain & Bean Cooking Ratios

Water, time, and what "done" should look like — stovetop guide

COOKING GRAINS (STOVETOP, SIMMER + LID)

GRAIN (1 CUP DRY)	WATER	SIMMER TIME	YIELD	"DONE" LOOKS LIKE
White rice, long grain	1¾ cups	18 min + 10 rest	3 cups	Fluffy, grains separate
Brown rice	2 cups	40–45 min + 10 rest	3 cups	Tender but chewy
Quinoa	2 cups	15 min	3 cups	Little white spirals appear
Old-fashioned oats	2 cups	5 min	2 cups	Creamy, no white hard center
Steel-cut oats	3 cups	25–30 min	3 cups	Chewy porridge
Millet	2½ cups	20 min	3½ cups	Fluffy, slightly sticky
Farro (pearled)	2½ cups	20–25 min	3 cups	Pleasantly al dente
Barley (pearled)	3 cups	30–40 min	3½ cups	Soft, plump
Couscous (pearled)	1½ cups	10 min	2½ cups	Tender, soybean-sized pearls
Bulgar	2 cups	12–15 min	2½ cups	Barely chewy

Always rinse rice and quinoa well in a sieve first. Add a ½ tsp salt per cup of water. Don't peek before the time is up — steam escapes and finish goes uneven.

COOKING DRIED BEANS (STOVETOP) — SOAKING FIRST

BEAN (1 LB DRY)	SOAK	SIMMER TIME	YIELD
Black beans	Overnight soak (or skip)	60–90 min (skip soak: +20–30 min)	6 cups cooked
Pinto beans	Overnight soak	60–90 min	6 cups cooked
White beans (cannellini/ northern)	Overnight soak	60–90 min	6 cups cooked
Chickpeas	Overnight soak (or slow soak)	90–120 min	6 cups cooked
Lentils, brown/green (no soak)	—	20–30 min	2½ cups cooked per cup dry
Lentils, red (no soak)	—	15–20 min	Cooks fast, gets very soft — great for dal
Split peas (no soak)	—	40–45 min	Softens to porridge
Black-eyed peas	Overnight soak (or skip)	45–60 min	Stays firm

PRESSURE-COOKER / INSTANT POT TIMES (HIGH PRESSURE, 1 : 1 WATER FOR GRAINS)

FOOD	COOK TIME	RELEASE
White rice	4–5 min	Natural 10 min
Brown rice	22–25 min	Natural 10 min
Quinoa	1 min	Natural 10 min
Soaked black/pinto beans	20–25 min	Natural 15 min
Soaked chickpeas	30–40 min	Natural 15 min
Unsoaked black/pinto	35–40 min	Natural 20 min

Safety must-knows: Baking soda can speed softening, but it destroys thiamine and turns mushy — skip it. Salt late in cooking; salt from the start can keep skins firm (some cooks like it). Kidney beans in particular must reach a full rolling boil for at least 10 minutes to break down their natural toxin (raw kidney beans contain more of it; slow-cookers at low temps can leave it intact — boil first, then simmer or pressure-cook). Fava beans can cause serious illness in anyone with G6PD deficiency (favism). Bay leaves, onion, and a strip of kombu are kind companions.